Forum:	Human Rights Council
Issue:	Ensuring the protection of media workers and journalists in conflict zones
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Introduction

Journalists in armed conflicts have a crucial function of providing information about situations that might be otherwise ignored. They can report on civilian suffering, humanitarian needs, displacement, military activities, and violations of international law. This makes journalism in war zones directly linked to the rights to freedom of expression and access to information. Article 19 of the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights guarantees the right to seek, receive, and impart information via any media.[1]

Nevertheless, journalists who operate in war zones usually have to confront various threats to their lives, livelihoods, reputations and equipment. Local journalists and freelancers might be at higher risk, as they might not have the means of protection or international attention enjoyed by prominent foreign correspondents. UNESCO has stressed that the safety of journalists is an issue of prevention, protection, and prosecution, particularly where attacks on journalists are not investigated and perpetrators go unpunished.[2]

In relation to international humanitarian law, one has to bear in mind the fact that journalists performing professional duties in areas of armed conflict are considered civilians, unless and for such time as they directly participate in hostilities.[3] Nevertheless, implementing such protection can be difficult because journalists may work in proximity to military objectives, under the authority of armed groups or in areas where access is extremely limited. Thus, the problem calls for considering how the existing international norms could be implemented, as well as the way in which States and armed groups could be held accountable and how journalists could be protected.

[1] United Nations General Assembly. (1966, December 16). International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights. Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights. https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/international-covenant-civil-and-political-rights

[2] United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization. UN Plan of Action on the Safety of Journalists and the Issue of Impunity. https://www.unesco.org/en/safety-journalists/un-plan-action

[3] International Committee of the Red Cross. (2026, June 2). Frequently asked questions: How does international humanitarian law protect journalists? https://www.icrc.org/en/article/international-humanitarian-law-protect-journalists-armed-conflict

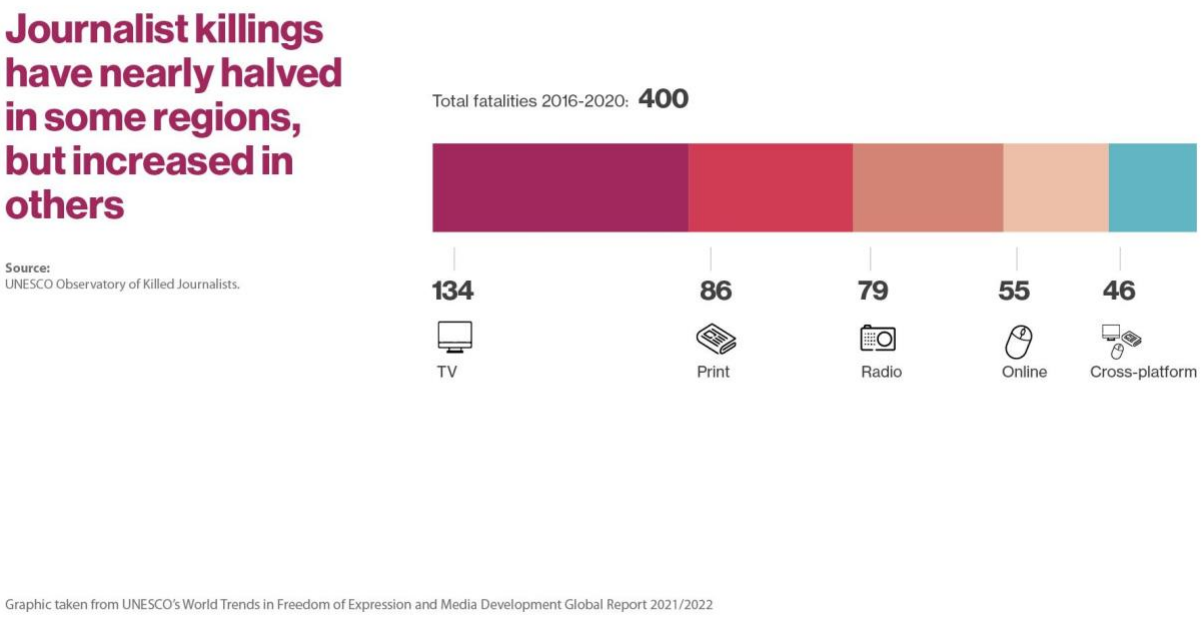


Figure 1: Graph illustrating the number of journalists killed by type of media between 2016 and 2020.[4]

Key Terms and Definitions

Conflict Zone

A conflict zone is an area affected by armed conflict. This can include places where the military is operating or where people are in danger because of it.[5]

International Humanitarian Law

International humanitarian law is a set of rules that limits the effects of war. It protects people who are not fighting and limits the means and methods of warfare.[6]

War Correspondent

A war correspondent is a journalist who is authorised to accompany armed forces without being a member of those forces. If an authorised war correspondent falls into enemy hands during an international armed conflict, they are entitled to prisoner-of-war status.[7]

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[4] United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization. (2022). Journalism is a public good: World trends in freedom of expression and media development; Global report 2021/2022. https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000380618.

[5] Protocol Additional to the Geneva Conventions of 12 August 1949, and Relating to the Protection of Victims of International Armed Conflicts (Protocol I), art. 79, June 8, 1977, 1125 U.N.T.S. 3. https://ihl-databases.icrc.org/en/ihl-treaties/api-1977/article-79

[6] International Committee of the Red Cross. (2022, July 5). What is international humanitarian law? https://www.icrc.org/en/document/what-international-humanitarian-law

[7] International Committee of the Red Cross. (2016, May). Glossary: International humanitarian law for media professionals. https://www.icrc.org/en/download/file/58487/glossary_ihl_for_journalists_october_2017.pdf

Freedom of Expression and Press Freedom

People have the right to share and get information. Journalists and news companies have the right to do their jobs without unlawful interference. Restrictions on freedom of expression may be lawful only where they meet the requirements of international human rights law.[8]

Impunity

Impunity is when people who commit crimes are not punished. It happens when the authorities do not investigate or when the courts do not punish the individuals who broke the law.[9]

Prisoner of War (PoW)

A Prisoner of War is a person belonging to a protected category under international humanitarian law who has fallen into enemy hands during an international armed conflict. Prisoners of War are protected under the Third Geneva Convention.[10]

Media War

Media War is the strategic use of the media during a conflict with the goal of influencing public opinion, strengthening the support for one side or weakening the support for another side.[11]

Background Information

Historical Development of War Reporting

The evolution of war reporting coincided with the evolution of newspapers, photography, radio, TV and the Internet as media outlets. In the nineteenth century, correspondents like William Howard Russell, who covered the Crimean War for The Times, established the archetype of the modern war correspondent who directly witnessed military campaigns and conveyed their realities to readers.[12] Thus, relations between war, governments and citizens were transformed because the events happening on the field could affect public opinion.

In the twentieth century, war reporting was more structured but also more controlled. In the First and the Second World Wars, journalists often operated in conditions of censorship policies and accreditation rules of the military. On the other hand, with the advent of photography, radio

[8] Human Rights Committee. (2011, September 12). General comment No. 34: Article 19: Freedoms of opinion and expression (CCPR/C/GC/34). United Nations. https://www2.ohchr.org/english/bodies/hrc/docs/gc34.pdf

[9] Orentlicher, D. (2005, February 8). Updated set of principles for the protection and promotion of human rights through action to combat impunity (E/CN.4/2005/102/Add.1). United Nations Economic and Social Council. https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/541829

[10] International Committee of the Red Cross. (2020). Commentary on the Third Geneva Convention: Article 4—Prisoners of war. IHL Databases. https://ihl-databases.icrc.org/en/ihl-treaties/gciii-1949/article-4/commentary/2020

[11] North Atlantic Treaty Organization. (2025, February 3). NATO's approach to counter information threats. https://www.nato.int/en/what-we-do/wider-activities/natos-approach-to-counter-information-threats

[12] RTÉ Brainstorm. (2024, August 21). How William Howard Russell invented modern war reporting. https://www.rte.ie/brainstorm/2024/0821/1403650-william-howard-russell-war-journalism-reporting-profile-ireland/.

broadcasting and newsreels, civilians could learn more about the wars than ever before. The appearance of these technologies turned journalism into an essential part of how societies perceived war but at the same time made journalists more noticeable for the military authorities and politicians.

Another crucial watershed is associated with the Vietnam War. It has been characterized as one of the first "media wars" because there was more extensive coverage of the conflict by newspapers and television cameras than in the previous wars.[13] The images of battles, the suffering of civilians, and military blunders were seen by common people in their homes, revealing the ability of journalists to influence the perception of a conflict. Nonetheless, this made the relationship between the government, military forces, and press even more problematic, since critical reporting sometimes contradicted official military accounts, weakened public confidence, and created tensions.

In the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries, war journalism saw some changes. Conflicts in the Balkans, Iraq, Afghanistan, Syria, Ukraine, Sudan and Gaza have demonstrated that journalists are not just representatives of international press agencies. Nowadays local journalists, freelance reporters, cameramen, interpreters, fixers, and citizen journalists have become indispensable sources of information from the battlefields. According to international humanitarian law, journalists in the zones of armed conflicts are civilians as long as they do not directly participate in hostilities.[14]

Currently, journalists working in conflict zones are confronted by both conventional and contemporary threats. They can be murdered, wounded, kidnapped, arrested, intimidated or even suspected of spying. They can also be subject to surveillance through the use of computers, online harassment, internet blackouts, and disinformation. The statistics gathered by UNESCO on murdered journalists and the records kept by the Committee to Protect Journalists (CPJ) on this matter show that violence against journalists is still an international problem particularly in conflict zones.[15] Hence, the evolution of war journalism over the years clearly indicates that as journalism was becoming significant in disseminating information to the people, journalists were becoming more vulnerable to violence.

[13] National Archives. (2021, April 20). The war in Vietnam: A story in photographs. https://www.archives.gov/education/lessons/vietnam-photos.

[14] International Committee of the Red Cross. (2026, June 2). Frequently asked questions: How does international humanitarian law protect journalists? https://www.icrc.org/en/article/international-humanitarian-law-protect-journalists-armed-conflict.

[15] United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization. Observatory of killed journalists. https://www.unesco.org/en/safety-journalists/observatory

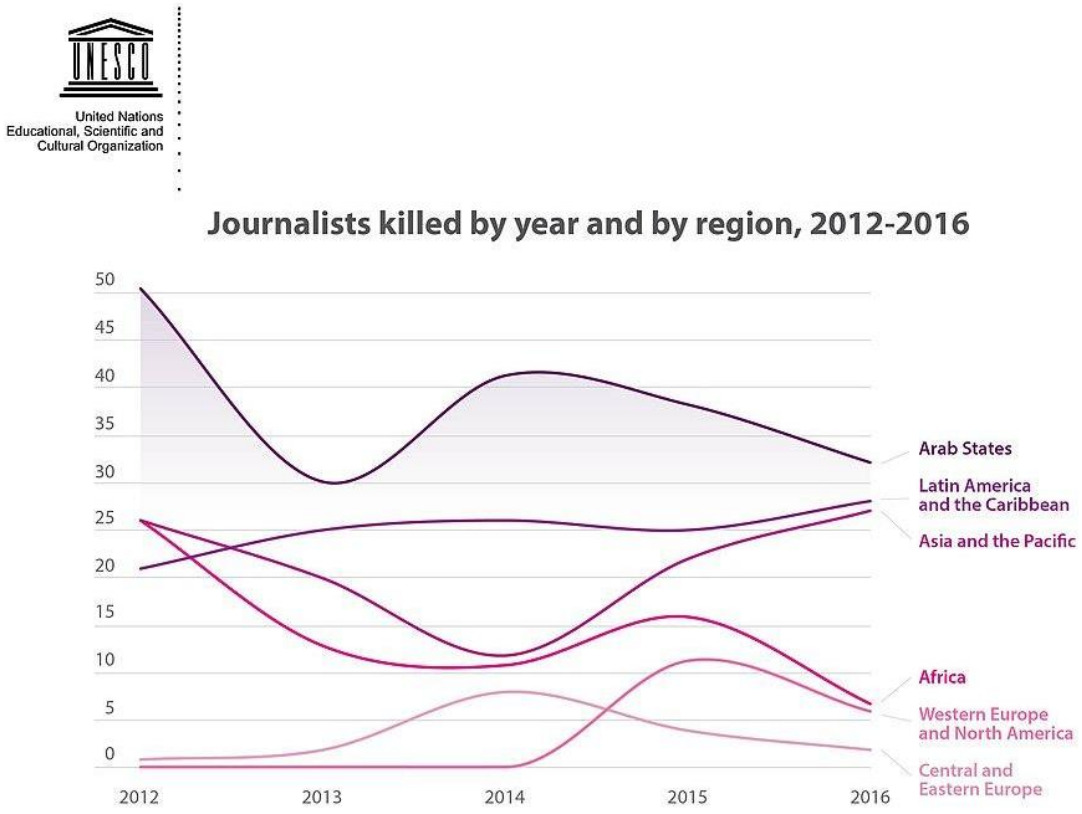


Figure 2: Graph presenting the number of journalists killed by year and region from 2012 to 2016.[16]

Legal Status and Protection of Journalists

Journalists operating in conflict areas enjoy protection under international humanitarian law and international human rights law. International humanitarian law covers situations of war and regulates the conduct of states, armed forces, and other parties to the conflict. International human rights law continues to ensure fundamental rights such as freedom of expression, protection against arbitrary detention, and the right to receive information. The combined effect of the two bodies of law is that the work of journalists in disseminating information and bringing to light the suffering of civilians and possible violation of international laws is recognized.[17]

International humanitarian law considers civilian journalists to be civilians. It means that they must not be deliberately attacked on account of their profession of reporting from a zone of armed conflict. According to Article 79 of the Additional Protocol I to the Geneva Conventions, journalists conducting hazardous professional missions in zones of armed conflict are to be treated as civilians

[16] United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization. (2018). World trends in freedom of expression and media development: Global report 2017/2018. https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000261065.

[17] International Committee of the Red Cross. (2026, June 2). Frequently asked questions: How does international humanitarian law protect journalists? https://www.icrc.org/en/article/international-humanitarian-law-protect-journalists-armed-conflict

provided that they do not directly participate in hostilities.[18] Journalists may be either international or local and employed in big media organizations or self-employed.

Protection of journalists in times of war has been recognized by the Security Council as well. Resolution 2222 reiterated that journalists, media professionals, and their support staff were entitled to be treated as civilians unless they directly took part in hostilities. Attacks on journalists including killing, kidnapping, taking hostages, arbitrary arrests, and threatening journalists were also condemned in the resolution.[19] Therefore, it is evident that protection of journalists is not a matter of law alone, but an issue of international peace and security.

An independent category is established for war correspondents. War correspondents are the journalists who have been given authorization to accompany armed forces, though not becoming a member of those forces. Under the Third Geneva Convention, authorized war correspondents are entitled to prisoner-of-war status if they fall into enemy hands in an international armed conflict. This shows that journalists operating near armed forces are not combatants solely by virtue of accompanying armed forces.

On the other hand, journalists lose protection against direct attack only for such time as they directly participate in hostilities. Direct participation does not include journalism-related functions like reporting, recording, interviewing combatants, criticizing, and recording military operations. The term involves specific actions such as participating in the military operations of one side by fighting with weapons, collecting tactical intelligence for use in an attack, and planning military operations.[20]

Human rights laws also protect journalists under the freedom of expression. According to article 19 of the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights, all people have the right to seek, receive, and impart information and ideas through any media.[21] Hence, the protection of journalists in conflict zones not only involves safeguarding them against attacks but also in safeguarding their right to disseminate information.

[18] International Committee of the Red Cross. (1977, June 8). Protocol Additional to the Geneva Conventions of 12 August 1949, and relating to the protection of victims of international armed conflicts: Article 79—Measures of protection for journalists. IHL Databases. https://ihl-databases.icrc.org/en/ihl-treaties/api-1977/article-79

[19] United Nations Security Council. (2015, May 27). Resolution 2222 (2015) (S/RES/2222). United Nations Digital Library. https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/793613

[20] Protocol Additional to the Geneva Conventions of 12 August 1949, and Relating to the Protection of Victims of International Armed Conflicts (Protocol I), art. 51(3), June 8, 1977, 1125 U.N.T.S. 3. https://ihl-databases.icrc.org/en/ihl-treaties/api-1977/article-51

[21] United Nations General Assembly. (1966, December 16). International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights. Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights. https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/international-covenant-civil-and-political-rights

Threats Faced by Journalists in Conflict Zones

Journalists working in conflict areas encounter various dangers since they have to report in areas of conflict, military checkpoints, destroyed civilian infrastructure, and operations by armed actors. The dangers include killings, injuries from shelling or airstrikes, kidnappings, torture, arbitrary arrests, and enforced disappearances. The United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) has an observatory on killed journalists that demonstrates that deaths of journalists are a continuous international issue.[22]

Other dangers are the limitations that journalists face in carrying out their job. Some of the limitations include censorship, restrictions on access to the conflict area, confiscation of equipment, destruction of media outlets, internet blackouts, and pressures from the States and armed actors. Media workers reporting from conflict areas like Israel-Palestine, Russia–Ukraine, and Sudan have been exposed to physical dangers, security limitations and difficulty in verifying information under a rapidly changing and politically charged environment.

Local reporters are particularly vulnerable, as they may remain in the conflict area after international reporters leave. Local journalists may be without protective gear, an evacuation plan or the security that comes from being part of a large media company. The same applies to freelancers who might not have any kind of contract or medical help.[23]

Gender-based threats are also an important danger to journalists, including sexual assault, gender-based harassment, threatening family members of journalists, and online harassment. Digital technologies are increasingly becoming a threat to journalists, including hacking, spyware, doxxing, surveillance, and manipulation of information. That is why the UN Plan of Action on the Safety of Journalists focuses on prevention, protection, and prosecution of crimes against journalists in both physical and digital ways.[24]

Challenges in Implementing International Protections

Even though there are many protective provisions of international humanitarian law and international human rights law regarding journalists, the enforcement of the laws during times of armed conflict proves to be challenging. For example, armed conflicts might lead to destruction or weakening of the institutions charged with enforcement of the law. Courts can be disabled; police can lack control over the area, and investigators may not be able to reach the place of the attack. Moreover, evidence can be destroyed due to the ongoing tensions, witnesses can be forced to relocate, be

[22] United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization. Observatory of killed journalists. https://www.unesco.org/en/safety-journalists/observatory

[23] Committee to Protect Journalists. Explore CPJ's database of attacks on the press. https://cpj.org/data/

[24] United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization. UN Plan of Action on the Safety of Journalists and the Issue of Impunity. https://www.unesco.org/en/safety-journalists/un-plan-action

intimidated or refuse to testify. All of this makes it hard to establish liability and prosecute the offenders.[25]

Another problem in implementation of the law during armed conflicts is the presence of non-state armed groups. International humanitarian law provides protection for civilians during armed conflicts and binds all parties to the conflict, including organized armed groups, however, organizations of this kind may lack certain legal infrastructure, military experience and accountability mechanisms comparable to those of states.

National security interests could also lead to disputes regarding the protection of journalists. The government and the armed forces might want to impose restrictions on access to front lines, military sites, or other sensitive locations in order to ensure safety of the military activities or civilian population. Nevertheless, such restrictions could undermine independent journalism and make the verification of the information more complicated. Restrictions on freedom of expression, permitted under international human rights law must be provided by law and be necessary and proportionate to a legitimate aim.[26]

The contemporary nature of conflicts brings about additional challenges, such as electronic surveillance, the shutdown of the internet, cyber attacks, and disinformation. The journalists could face monitoring or attacks through digital technologies even if they do not operate near the battlefield. In this way, the efficiency of the current international regulations would rely not only on their existence but also on the willingness and the ability of the states and the armed organizations to abide by those rules.[27]

Impunity and Accountability

Impunity is one of the major factors behind the continuing attacks on journalists. This term describes the situations in which people are guilty of murdering, kidnapping, torturing, or attacking journalists, but they are not investigated, tried or punished. As was noted by UNESCO in 2024, 85% of journalist killings recorded by UNESCO since 2006 were considered judicially unresolved.[28]

There could be many reasons why such crimes do not end with prosecution of the perpetrators. These can include absence of evidence, insufficient financial resources, corruption, political influence,

[25] International Committee of the Red Cross. (2026, June 2). Frequently asked questions: How does international humanitarian law protect journalists? https://www.icrc.org/en/article/international-humanitarian-law-protect-journalists-armed-conflict.

[26] Human Rights Committee. (2011, September 12). General comment No. 34: Article 19: Freedoms of opinion and expression (CCPR/C/GC/34). United Nations. https://www.ohchr.org/sites/default/files/english/bodies/hrc/docs/gc34.pdf

[27] United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization. (2022). Threats that silence: Trends in the safety of journalists. https://unesdoc.unesco.org/

[28] United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization. (2024, November 2). 85% of journalist killings remain unpunished worldwide (UNESCO report). https://www.unesco.org/en/articles/85-journalist-killings-remain-unpunished-worldwide-unesco-report

intimidation of witnesses, involvement of powerful military or political figures in the crime. In the case of conflicts, damaged institutions and high levels of insecurity can exacerbate this problem. Lack of prosecution of people that commit crimes against journalists creates an image that there is no risk in committing these crimes, and this can lead to the continuation of attacks on journalists.[29]

Thus, increased accountability implies the need for independent investigations, well-prepared prosecutors, witness protection, protection of evidence and a fair judiciary. Cooperation with international organizations may be needed in case perpetrators cross borders or domestic authorities are either unwilling or unable to investigate these crimes.



Figure 3: Graph showing the impacts of online violence against women journalists.[30]

Timeline of Events

Date	Description of Events

[29] Heyns, C. (2012, April 10). Report of the Special Rapporteur on extrajudicial, summary or arbitrary executions (A/HRC/20/22). United Nations Human Rights Council. https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/725333

[30] Posetti, J., Aboulez, N., Bontcheva, K., Harrison, J., & Waisbord, S. (2020). Online violence against women journalists: A global snapshot of incidence and impacts. International Center for Journalists & UNESCO. https://www.icfj.org/sites/default/files/2020-12/UNESCO%20Online%20Violence%20Against%20Women%20Journalists%20-%20A%20Global%20Snapshot%20Dec9pm.pdf.

10 December 1948	The General Assembly adopted the Universal Declaration of Human Rights. Article 19, in particular, established the right to freedom of expression, including the right to seek, receive, and share information.[31]
12 August 1949	The Third Geneva Convention was adopted. Article 4(A)(4) recognized authorized war correspondents accompanying armed forces as persons entitled to prisoner-of-war status, should they be captured.[32]
8 June 1977	Additional Protocol I to the Geneva Conventions was adopted. Article 79 specifically recognized journalists carrying out dangerous professional missions in armed conflict areas as civilians.[33]
23 December 2006	The Security Council adopted Resolution 1738. It condemned armed attacks against journalists and media professionals in armed conflict.[34]
18 December 2013	The General Assembly adopted Resolution 68/163 on the safety of journalists and the issue of impunity. It also proclaimed the 2nd of November as the International Day to End Impunity for Crimes against Journalists.[35]
27 May 2015	The Security Council adopted Resolution 2222. It strengthened international attention against killings, kidnappings, hostage-taking, arbitrary detentions, and threats against journalists in

[31] United Nations General Assembly. (1948, December 10). Universal Declaration of Human Rights (A/RES/217(III)). United Nations. https://www.un.org/en/about-us/universal-declaration-of-human-rights

[32] International Committee of the Red Cross. (1949, August 12). Geneva Convention (III) relative to the treatment of prisoners of war: Article 4—Prisoners of war. IHL Databases. https://ihl-databases.icrc.org/en/ihl-treaties/gciii-1949/article-4

[33] International Committee of the Red Cross. (1977, June 8). Protocol Additional to the Geneva Conventions of 12 August 1949, and relating to the protection of victims of international armed conflicts: Article 79—Measures of protection for journalists. IHL Databases. https://ihl-databases.icrc.org/en/ihl-treaties/api-1977/article-79

[34] United Nations Security Council. (2006, December 23). Resolution 1738 (2006) (S/RES/1738). United Nations Digital Library. https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/589659

[35] United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization. (2022, November 2). 10th anniversary of the UN Plan of Action on the Safety of Journalists. https://www.unesco.org/en/articles/10th-anniversary-un-plan-action-safety-journalists

	armed conflict.[36]
6 October 2020	The Human Rights Council adopted Resolution 45/18 on the safety of journalists. It addressed both online and offline attacks and threats against journalists.[37]
18 December 2025	The General Assembly adopted Resolution 80/217 on the safety of journalists and the issue of impunity. It reflected newer concerns such as online attacks, surveillance, disinformation, and digital threats to journalists.[38]

Major Actors Involved

Israel

Israel is an important stakeholder in the issue because of its involvement in the Israel-Palestine conflict and the effects of military operations on journalists working in Gaza and its environs. Journalists' protection in this situation touches upon such issues as accessibility to the conflict zones, security of military actions, the differentiation of civilians from combatants, and the safety of journalists during the military conflicts. The issue is further complicated by disputes over whether certain individuals should be regarded as journalists or as participants in hostilities, which led CPJ to review its documentation in 2026.[39]

Palestine

Palestine is relevant because the Palestinian territories, particularly Gaza, are a major setting for conflict-related reporting and restrictions on journalism. Within Gaza, journalists work amid both the activities of the Israeli army and the pressure from Hamas on local journalism. CPJ has highlighted how journalists working in Gaza were subjected to intimidation by Hamas, indicating that threats for journalists may be coming not only from the environment of the conflict but also from the actions of non-state armed groups.[40]

[36] United Nations Security Council. (2015, May 27). Resolution 2222 (2015) (S/RES/2222). United Nations Digital Library. https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/793613

[37] United Nations Human Rights Council. (2020, October 6). The safety of journalists (A/HRC/RES/45/18). United Nations Digital Library. https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/3888335

[38] United Nations General Assembly. (2025, December 22). The safety of journalists and the issue of impunity (A/RES/80/217). United Nations Digital Library. https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/4098510

[39] Committee to Protect Journalists. (2026, June 25). CPJ undertakes review of its documentation of journalists killed in Israel-Gaza war since 2023. https://cpj.org/2026/06/cpj-undertakes-review-of-its-documentation-of-journalists-killed-in-israel-gaza-war-since-2023/

[40] Committee to Protect Journalists. Israel-Gaza war. https://cpj.org/issue/israel-gaza-war/

Ukraine

Ukraine's role is significant as the war between Russia and Ukraine has generated considerable dangers for journalists both from Ukraine and from abroad. The media has been present at front lines, in cities being shelled, and in occupied territories or in areas where there have been cases of population displacements. The work of the media has revealed the humanitarian and political implications of the conflict; however, it has also increased the threats to the safety of the reporters – shelling, attacks with drones, detention, injuries, and even death.[41]

The Russian Federation

Russia is an important player in this regard as it is a participant in the Russia-Ukraine war and the war has affected the media situation both within Russia and in the occupied Ukrainian territories. The Russian Federation's involvement in the topic is significant when considering issues such as the safety of journalists, censorship during the time of war, propaganda, accessing conflict zones, and restriction of independent coverage of events. The Russia-Ukraine war clearly illustrates that the dangers for journalists do not always consist in military conflict alone.[42]

Sudan

The significance of Sudan comes from the fact that the civil war between the Sudanese Army and the Rapid Support Forces has made it extremely difficult for the media to report independently. Journalists operating in Sudan have been threatened with violence, arbitrary arrest, kidnapping, and even death by both the Sudanese Armed Forces and the Rapid Support Forces. The conflict has also reduced the opportunity for both civilians and the international community to get any credible information. Sudan serves as an example of how internal armed conflicts may lead to media silence, loss of accountability, and endangerment of the local journalists.[43]

Committee to Protect Journalists

The Committee to Protect Journalists is a private, non-profit organization that focuses on promoting press freedom and defending the rights of journalists around the world. The role of CPJ with regard to this topic entails recording incidents of attack on journalists, having databases on journalists who have been killed or detained, releasing public warnings, and advocating for justice. The CPJ's contributions are important, since it can help to provide important information about the safety of journalists during both conflict and non-conflict times.[44]

UN Documents and International Agreements

[41] Committee to Protect Journalists. Russia-Ukraine war. https://cpj.org/invasion-of-ukraine/

[42] Reporters Without Borders. Russia. https://rsf.org/en/country/russia

[43] Committee to Protect Journalists. (2026, April 15). Sudan's 3 years of war, impunity, and the silencing of the press. https://cpj.org/2026/04/sudans-3-years-of-war-impunity-and-the-silencing-of-the-press/

[44] Committee to Protect Journalists. What we do. https://cpj.org/about/

International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights

The International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights was adopted by the General Assembly on 16 December 1966 and entered into force on 23 March 1976. Article 19 of the Covenant guarantees freedom of expression, which involves the right to seek, receive and impart information. This article is relevant to journalists because it creates binding obligations for States Parties to respect and protect freedom of expression, subject to the restrictions permitted by Article 19(3). The problem with this article is that its application relies greatly on implementation at the national level, where restrictions in journalism still happen.[45]

Additional Protocol I to the Geneva Conventions

The Additional Protocol I to the Geneva Conventions was adopted on 8 June 1977 with the aim of enhancing the protection of victims of international armed conflict. Article 79 of the protocol clearly states that any journalist undertaking a dangerous professional mission is considered a civilian, hence should be protected against direct attack unless and for such time as they participate directly in hostilities. The effect of this protocol was to reaffirm the civilian status of journalists within international humanitarian laws. However, the ICRC still reports deaths, detentions, kidnappings, censorships, and access restrictions to journalists.[46]

UN Security Council Resolution 1738

The UN Security Council Resolution 1738 was unanimously adopted on 23 December 2006. This was the first resolution by the UN Security Council that addressed the issue of journalists in armed conflict situations. This resolution condemned intentional attacks on journalists and reinforced the need for their protection as civilians. This resolution greatly elevated the international concern for the safety of journalists as a component of the safety of civilians in war. Yet, it is based solely on compliance with international law by States and warring parties.[47]

UN Security Council Resolution 2222

Resolution 2222 of the UN Security Council was adopted unanimously on 27 May 2015 and built on Resolution 1738. It covered the problems of murders, kidnappings, hostages, arbitrary arrests, threats, impunity, and the protection of media personnel in armed conflicts, calling for an independent and effective investigation process. However, it should be noted that the application is uneven due to the fact that accountability depends primarily on the efforts of national bodies and the parties to the

[45] United Nations General Assembly. (1966, December 16). International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights (A/RES/2200A(XXI)). Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights. https://www.ohchr.org/en/instruments-mechanisms/instruments/international-covenant-civil-and-political-rights

[46] International Committee of the Red Cross. (1977, June 8). Protocol Additional to the Geneva Conventions of 12 August 1949, and relating to the protection of victims of international armed conflicts: Article 79—Measures of protection for journalists. IHL Databases. https://ihl-databases.icrc.org/en/ihl-treaties/api-1977/article-79

[47] United Nations Security Council. (2006, December 23). Resolution 1738 (2006) (S/RES/1738). United Nations Digital Library. https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/589659

conflict themselves, with the UNESCO report of 2024 indicating that 85% of journalist killings from 2006 were considered unresolved.[48]

Previous Attempts to Solve the issue

Committee to Protect Journalists — Journalist Safety and Emergency Assistance

The CPJ offers emergency assistance to journalists whose safety has been compromised due to their professional activity. The aid may include emergency relocation, medical care, legal assistance, psychological support, assistance during detention, and security consultations. The reason why this project is so vital is that it helps journalists who find themselves in serious trouble by providing direct aid. However, according to CPJ, due to the numerous applications for help, not all applicants receive the help they need.[49]

Reporters Without Borders — Assistance to Journalists and Media

In terms of protection, Reporters Without Borders offers tangible assistance to journalists threatened or operating in dangerous surroundings through their various programmes that offer protective equipment, insurance, financial aid, administration help, security training, and practical advice. This is helpful in reducing certain physical and financial risks when reporting from areas of conflict. However, this kind of assistance will not stop all attacks nor can it make authorities and armed forces respect the journalists, in addition to the fact that there could be limitations on some programmes.[50]

International News Safety Institute — INSI Safety Code

The INSI Safety Code was created by the International News Safety Institute in order to address some of the unnecessary dangers that journalists face when operating in perilous conditions. This code promotes the need for media companies to carry out risk assessments, give adequate safety training and equipment, and ensure that dangerous assignments are undertaken voluntarily by employees. The major strength of the INSI code is that it has managed to set out clear professional guidelines for the news media when sending journalists to conflict areas. Yet, it is still voluntary.[51]

Media Defence — Legal Defence and Strategic Litigation

Media Defence was founded in 2008 as an organization offering legal defence for journalists and independent media outlets who find themselves legally threatened due to their activities. It includes the financing of lawyers, emergency legal assistance, establishing local legal centres, and taking on strategic cases aimed at challenging media laws. Media Defence states that it has supported over 2,000 cases in 120 countries. Legal support provided by the organization has helped to enhance access to

[48] United Nations Security Council. (2015, May 27). Resolution 2222 (2015) (S/RES/2222). United Nations Digital Library. https://digitallibrary.un.org/record/793613

[49] Committee to Protect Journalists. Journalist safety and emergencies. https://cpj.org/journalist-safety-and-emergencies/,

[50] Reporters Without Borders. Assistance to journalists and media. https://rsf.org/en/assistance-journalists-and-media.

[51] International News Safety Institute.. INSI Safety Code. https://newssafety.org/insi-safety-code/

legal assistance for journalists under threat, but legal aid alone does not protect from physical assault or court decisions being ignored.[52]

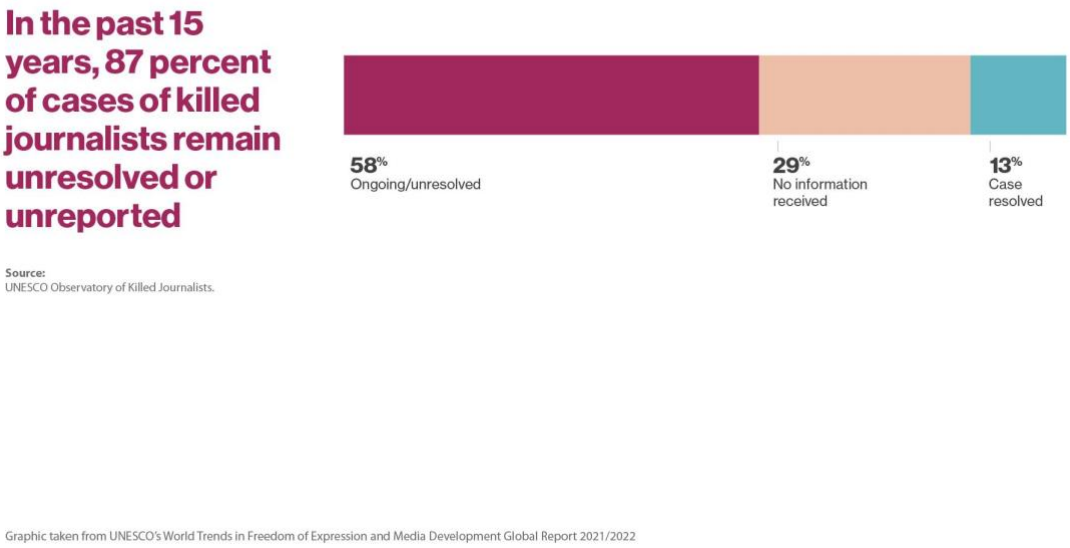


Figure 4: Status of judicial inquiries into killings of journalists. Source: UNESCO Observatory of Killed Journalists.[53]

Possible Solutions

Strengthening Accountability Mechanisms for Crimes Against Journalists

Member States could reinforce domestic mechanisms for investigation and prosecution of crimes against journalists in conflict situations. It may consist of the creation of a special prosecutor's office, an independent investigatory body, witness protection and collaboration with international organizations. The reason for accountability is that, usually, attacks on journalists are not sanctioned, which makes perpetrators believe that they can keep on being violent. By identifying suspects, investigating allegations and prosecuting offences, states can demonstrate that journalists cannot be targeted and that international humanitarian and human rights law violations will be punished.

Establishing Emergency Protection Systems for Media Workers

The international community could assist in creating emergency protection mechanisms for journalists working in dangerous regions. They might consist of establishing an emergency hotline, temporary shelter facilities, evacuation assistance, medical services, protective gear and communication equipment. Particular emphasis should be placed on protection of local and freelance

[52] Media Defence. About us. https://www.mediadefence.org/about/

[53] United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization. (2021). Journalism is a public good: World trends in freedom of expression and media development; Global report 2021/2022. https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000380618.

journalists, as they do not have access to financial resources of international media companies. Such measures will not protect journalists from any dangers entirely, but will decrease them.

Punishing Armed Groups That Target Journalists

Member States need to consider taking measures against armed groups, militias, and terrorist groups who intentionally attack journalists. States may, where legally authorised, impose sanctions, restrict movements, freeze assets and pursue prosecution or arrest through competent national authorities and lawful international cooperation. The groups who resort to kidnapping, threats, torture, and killing of journalists may be held individually responsible for offences under applicable national or international law.

Combating Digital Threats, Surveillance, and Online Harassment Against Journalists

In modern times, protection of journalists also involves digital security. Journalists operating in conflict areas are exposed to hacking, spyware, online harassment, doxxing, disinformation, and internet blackouts. States and international organizations are expected to provide assistance to journalists when it comes to digital security by offering training, encrypted communication, and timely response to cyberattacks. Governments also need to prevent unlawful surveillance of journalists and investigate the crimes against them. With the development of modern journalism, there is a direct connection between protecting journalists digitally and physically.

Further reading

- Safety of Journalists - United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization[54]
- Basic Texts Related to the Safety of Journalists - United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization[55]
- OHCHR and the Safety of Journalists and the Issue of Impunity - Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights[56]
- Explore CPJ's Database of Attacks on the Press - Committee to Protect Journalists[57]

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[55] United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization. (2026, June 24). Basic texts related to the safety of journalists. https://www.unesco.org/en/safety-journalists/basic-texts

[56] Office of the United Nations High Commissioner for Human Rights. OHCHR and the safety of journalists and the issue of impunity. https://www.ohchr.org/en/safety-of-journalists

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